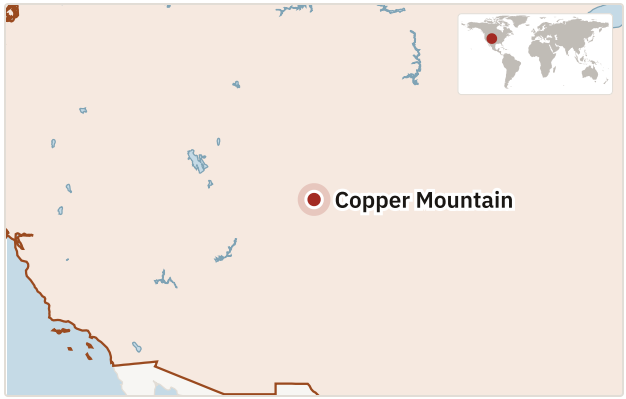
Copper Mountain and Frisco, Colorado

El Niño probably won't change this winter at Copper Mountain. Seventy years of records nearby show strong El Niño winters no snowier and no colder than any other. What kills people here is the ordinary high-mountain winter, meeting a workforce that sleeps in crowded units and in cars at 9,000 feet. Carbon monoxide, persistent-slab avalanches, and closed interstates are the weather risks. Suicide among men after a loss is the largest preventable toll, and it has nothing to do with snow. The most lives are saved by getting alarms into worker housing, keeping in touch with bereaved men, and agreeing now where stranded people will sleep when I-70 closes.

IMPACT REGION	EXCESS HEAT DEATHS	WINDOW	DOMINANT HAZARD
Summit County, Colorado (inferred; 30,882 residents, about a tenth of a typical region). Copper Mountain sits at its western edge, where I-70 meets Colorado 91 in Tenmile Canyon	None published for the US, Colorado, or the county	n/a here; the global 6-month figure is 239,000 ± 11,000 (heat only)	The ordinary mountain winter: carbon monoxide, persistent-slab avalanches, I-70 closures, and cold exposure for people living in vehicles. El Niño adds no

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE



39.57°N 106.10°W, United States of America · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** The ordinary mountain winter is the danger, not El Niño: carbon monoxide, persistent-slab avalanches, and I-70 closures, with a workforce sleeping in crowded units and cars at 9,000 feet.
- **First action.** Summit Fire & EMS, property managers, and employers put carbon monoxide alarms into worker housing and short-term rentals before 1 December.
- **The money.** $60k floor, $115k target, $265k ceiling; it goes to rent and heat arrears, bereavement outreach, and a carbon monoxide pilot, not to lodging, kits, or food drives.
- **Do not.** Do not assume a thin, slow-starting winter is a safer one: a shallow early snowpack grows the weak layers behind most Colorado avalanche deaths.

What to do	**14** actions	p. 5
Who does what	RACI chart	p. 15
Where money does the most	funding	p. 15
Do not do this	**7** items	p. 18
What has happened here	the record	p. 20
How this was produced	methodology	p. 22
References	sources	p. 24

			measurable snow or cold signal

21/21 recommendations checked. Of 14 proposed actions, 12 were corrected (partially confirmed) and 2 are unverified (a pre-season exercise and questions to the resort about worker housing and snow insurance). None was confirmed as written, and none was contraindicated. Of 7 proposed "do not" warnings, 4 were confirmed and 3 were narrowed.
Biggest corrections:

- Colorado already bars regulated utilities, including Xcel, from shutting off a home on any day the National Weather Service forecasts 32 °F or lower. Energy help here is about arrears, not winter shutoffs. LEAP takes applications until 30 April; 11 December is when its federal funding runs out, not a deadline.
- Advice to "clear the tailpipe" before sheltering in a car is not enough. In the study behind it, carbon monoxide stayed dangerous until a 12-inch path was cleared to the ground around the tailpipe.
- Overdose deaths among Summit residents fell from 19 in 2022 to 7 in 2024, so naloxone money now buys less, and its placement was cut to match the provider's scale.
- Cash for stranded travelers' lodging was dropped. In the February 2020 closure there were no rooms to buy; a sheltering agreement does more.

The funding target is $115k (floor $60k, ceiling $265k), down 12% from the $130k first proposed, inside the one-third flag. **The El Niño premise was tested, not assumed,** from 64 winters of records at Climax and 75 at Dillon. **Exposure figure:** Climate Impact Lab, September 2026, pre-peer-review, publishes none for the United States, Colorado, or the county, and heat is not this place's winter hazard.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

NOAA daily records for Climax (about 11,300 ft, roughly 10 km south of Copper, 64 winters from 1952–53 to 2025–26) and Dillon (about 9,100 ft, roughly 20 km northeast, 75 winters from 1950–51), classed by the peak October–February Oceanic Niño Index. Snow is November to March.

WINTERS	CLIMAX DEC–FEB MEAN (°C)	CLIMAX NIGHTS AT OR BELOW −18 °C	CLIMAX SNOW, NOV–MAR (CM)	CLIMAX DAYS WITH 15 CM OR MORE	DILLON DEC–FEB MEAN (°C)	DILLON SNOW, NOV–MAR (CM)
Strong El Niño (Climax 9, Dillon 8)	−9.6	39.3	411	6.6	−8.2	210
Moderate or weak El Niño	−9.7	43.7	469	7.4	−7.7	236
Neutral	−9.7	38.5	461	7.9	−8.0	209
La Niña	−9.8	39.7	477	7.7	−7.8	232
All winters	−9.7	40.1	461	7.5	−7.9	224

- **No cold signal.** Strong El Niño winters at Climax averaged −9.6 °C, against −9.7 °C for all winters, with about 40 nights at or below −18 °C (0 °F) either way. Every winter at both stations had multi-day runs averaging −7 °C or colder.
- **If anything, slightly less snow.** Strong El Niño winters averaged 411 cm at Climax, 11% below the all-winter mean, and 6% below at Dillon. The range is wide: from 264 to 495 cm at Climax. The snowiest winter on record there, 2010–11, was a La Niña.
- **Forecasters agree the signal is weak.** Analysis from the Colorado Climate Center, as reported by 9News, found the northern and central mountains tend to run below average in moderate to strong El Niños, and the National Weather Service calls the signal hard to call. OpenSnow finds "no clear signal in either direction" for the central mountains west of the Divide this winter.
- **Last winter was the bad one.** Colorado's statewide snowpack fell to about 24% of normal in late March 2026, after a record low in early March, and ski visits fell from 13.8 million to 10.5 million. A thin start this year would matter for avalanche conditions (action 4), whatever El Niño does.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

EXPOSURE, HONESTLY

WHO IS AT RISK, AND WHERE

- **Men after a loss.** The county coroner investigated 5 suicides in 2025, all men, and 8 from January to May 2026. Men were more than 80% of suicides from 2020 to 2025, and all eight people who died in 2026 had a loss in the six months before. The coroner says five months of data "does not indicate a trend." Summit's suicide rate was 17.4 per 100,000 over 2004–2020, against 14.5 nationally. No Summit figure for firearm share was found; statewide, about half of suicides involve a firearm.
- **People living in cars and crowded units.** Unsheltered in Summit's safe-parking program served about 65 people a year, all of them working, with a waitlist of about 20 in winter 2024–25; the winter lot is at the Frisco Bay Marina. A county housing study reported that 47% of Spanish speakers lived with someone sleeping on a couch or floor, against 8% of English speakers. Copper has had about 620 dorm-style beds for about 1,100 seasonal staff (a dated figure).
- **Carbon monoxide is the indoor killer the record keeps nearly producing.** A faulty furnace in Dillon Valley sent seven people to hospital on 7 December 2021, in a home with no detectors. On 6 April 2025 in a Silverthorne condo, residents tried to silence alarms they thought were faulty, and five went to hospital; the likely source was a rented hybrid car left powered in an underground garage. The next day a faulty kitchen appliance at Arapahoe Basin reached 2,000 ppm.
- **Overdose has fallen.** Summit residents' overdose deaths fell from 19 in 2022 to 12 in 2023 and 7 in 2024, after naloxone was scaled up from 2019. These are resident deaths; visitors and workers who die here may not be counted.
- **Skiers on intermediate runs.** One of the three Summit resort deaths in 2024–25 was at Copper, a 21-year-old without a helmet on an intermediate run. The other two, at Keystone, and Copper's death in January 2026, were helmeted.
- **The safety net is tightening.** About 700 Summit households (1,400 people) receive SNAP. Under the 2025 federal budget law, adults aged 18–64 without dependents must log 80 hours a month of work or volunteering, and Medicaid adults face checks every six months from 1 January 2027. Seasonal hours rise and fall with the snow.

HOW FOOD REACHES COPPER MOUNTAIN

SUPPLY CHAIN

The honest finding is that El Niño's food signal here is weak. Food comes up I-70 from Front Range warehouses; closures delay it by hours, and the break is the household budget.

- **Prices are moderate.** USDA's Economic Research Service (25 September 2026) forecasts food prices up 2.9% in 2026 and 2.0% in 2027, with a wide range for 2027 (–2.7% to 7.0%). Food-at-home prices in the Mountain region rose 0.7–2.9% a year through 2026.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **Closures delay food; they don't cut it off.** Closures on I-70 last hours. During the 2020 Glenwood Canyon closure on another stretch, the grocer rerouted trucks with a 6–8 hour delay. A lens's claim that a 2022 closure emptied Summit shelves could not be sourced.
- **The break is the paycheck.** The Family & Intercultural Resource Center (FIRC) runs free, no-ID food markets in Dillon and Breckenridge, with nearly 800 grocery appointments a week. In September 2025 it cut weekly food buying from $15,000 to $10,000 to hold reserves before SNAP cuts. Its pantry visits are up 350% since August 2020, from a low pandemic base. Most of the households it serves earn too much for SNAP.
- **School meals are secure.** Colorado voters passed Propositions LL and MM in November 2025, funding free school meals. They do nothing for adult seasonal workers.

WHAT THIS PLACE SHOULD DO — RANKED BY LIVES PER EFFORT

The first three actions carry most of the expected lives saved: they target the deaths the record shows, indoors and among men. Actions 4 to 7 cover the winter hazards and the money that keeps people housed and heated. Actions 8 to 11 keep the safety net from failing in a short-hours month. Actions 12 to 14 are for next summer and for the resort.

1. Put carbon monoxide alarms into worker housing and short-term rentals before 1 December, with one rule: never silence the alarm, get out, call 911

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · FRONTLINE · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CHECKED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Summit Fire & EMS (Copper station) with property managers and employers; Unsheltered in Summit and FIRC for people in vehicles	1 December	$10k pilot, about 400 alarms at $25 (arithmetic); installation not costed	The Dillon Valley and Silverthorne pattern: no detector, or a detector silenced

Colorado law (CRS 38-45-104) already requires carbon monoxide alarms in rentals with fuel-burning appliances or an attached garage, triggered at a change of tenant, and landlords must replace missing or dead alarms. The gap is enforcement and the units that change hands informally. Summit Fire & EMS doesn't run a free-alarm program, so a grant doesn't duplicate one. Carry a Spanish card to the safe-parking lot and FIRC markets: never run a propane heater in a closed car.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: Copper is served by Summit Fire & EMS, which absorbed Copper Mountain Fire in 2018. The Dillon Valley case was "7 people", on 7 December 2021; the Arapahoe Basin incident hospitalized no one. The pilot replaces the lens's $50k for 2,000 alarms because no delivery channel at that scale exists yet.

2. Reach men after a loss: bereavement outreach, lock boxes and gun locks, and 988 on every card

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FRONTLINE · PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CHECKED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Building Hope Summit County, with the Sheriff's SMART team (lock boxes and gun locks) and the coroner's grief group	Before the season's first big loss events; ongoing through spring	$40k top-up (see funding)	Suicide among men in the months after a death, divorce, injury, or job loss

All eight people who died by suicide in early 2026 had a loss in the six months before, which gives outreach a named route: the coroner's office, funeral homes, the SMART team, and employers know who has just lost someone. Building Hope already runs men's events and support groups. The SMART team hands out lock boxes and gun locks. Add means-safety counselling (putting time and distance between a person in crisis and a firearm or stockpiled medication) to every contact.*

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: the 21.9 per 100,000 rate a lens cited could not be sourced; 17.4 (2004–2020) is used. A local crisis line a lens named is not in the source. The youth study often cited for locked storage does not apply to adult men, and no trial shows storage devices reduce adult suicide; the adult evidence that household firearm access raises suicide risk is observational and was not re-checked here. Building Hope gets more than half its income from the county's Strong Future levy, so this is a top-up, not new capacity.

3. Agree a Copper-side warming site for I-70 closures by 15 November, and teach the car rule that actually works

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · FOOD SUPPLY · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CHECKED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Summit County Office of Emergency Management with the American Red Cross and the Copper Mountain Metropolitan District	15 November	Staff time; a written agreement, not cash	Drivers idling overnight in full lots, and carbon monoxide in snowbound cars

On 6–7 February 2020 a civil emergency closed I-70 and stranded 800 to 1,000 vehicles in Summit County with no hotel vacancies; the Red Cross opened shelters at the Silverthorne Recreation Center and Summit Middle School in Frisco. On 7 March 2019 a slide near the Vail Pass summit closed I-70 west of Copper for about 18 hours, while another slide near the Copper gas station ruptured a gas line and closed Colorado 91. Today's shelter sites are east of Copper. Agree a Copper-side site in advance, with pre-contracted food so shelters don't draw on residents' shelves, and enroll every seasonal hire in SC Alert, the county's emergency alerts, at onboarding. For anyone who must wait in a car: clear a 12-inch path to the ground around the tailpipe, run the engine in short bursts, and open a window.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: in 2019, Summit Fire said there were no evacuations, contrary to an early state patrol post. The claim of 99 full closures in 2024 could not be sourced. In the study behind the car advice (Griffin et al., BMC Emergency Medicine 2004), a buried sedan reached lethal carbon monoxide in 2.5 minutes with windows closed and 5 minutes with them cracked, and sweeping the tailpipe clear still left dangerous levels. A $15k lodging fund was dropped: there were no rooms to buy in 2020.

4. Post persistent-slab warnings at boundary gates from December to April, and treat sidecountry as backcountry

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | HISTORIAN · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CHECKED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Copper Mountain and neighboring resorts with the White River National Forest and the Colorado Avalanche Information Center (CAIC)	**December, when early-season slabs start**	**Signage and staff time**	**Deaths in terrain reached through resort gates**

Persistent and deep persistent slabs caused about 87% of Colorado's avalanche deaths from 1998–99 to 2012–13. On 20 April 2013 the Sheep Creek slide at Loveland Pass, just outside a ski area, killed five of six people caught; the experienced party had discussed the risk. CAIC counted 85 sidecountry accidents from 2009–10 to 2022–23, 10 of them fatal. CAIC's 2023–24 season summary tied a slow start and a weak, sugary base to an early-winter persistent-slab problem. Use the daily CAIC forecast, not seasonal outlooks.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: no CAIC or peer-reviewed source ties El Niño itself to slab risk; the evidence is about thin early snow. 2023–24 had only two deaths against a ten-year average of six, so it illustrates the mechanism, not a death toll. The claim that Summit ranks second in Colorado for avalanche deaths could not be verified. The window starts in December, not February.

5. Run LEAP enrollment drives from 1 November, and get claims in early in case federal funding lapses

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CHECKED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Summit County Human Services, with FIRC and clinics; the state's Low-income Energy Assistance Program (LEAP)	From 1 November; ideally before 11 December	Staff time; benefits paid from federal LIHEAP	Heating arrears that push households to improvised heat

LEAP's 2026–27 season opens 1 November and accepts applications until 30 April. Federal LIHEAP money is funded at last year's level only through a continuing resolution to 11 December 2026, and the administration's budget request again proposes eliminating it. Colorado's utility regulator bars regulated utilities, including Xcel, from disconnecting a home on any day the National Weather Service forecasts 32 °F or lower within 24 hours, which at 9,700 feet covers most winter days. A medical certificate delays a shutoff by up to 90 days in any 12 months, which matters most in the shoulder seasons.

Corrections: 11 December is a funding date, not an application deadline. The "pay 10% of arrears" condition a lens attached to the medical certificate comes from another utility's notice and was not found in Xcel's tariff. The cold-weather rule does not cover co-ops or municipal utilities.

6. Refill FIRC's emergency rent and utility fund for the winter

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PHILANTHROPIST · ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CHECKED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
FIRC (Family & Intercultural Resource Center)	December to April	$50k (see funding)	Evictions into cars and arrears that end in shutoffs in spring

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

In October 2025 FIRC's workforce rent fund was "completely depleted". It asked the county and each town for $10,000, and only Dillon committed. Payments are capped at about $800 a household.

Corrections: a lens's figure of $361,397 to 672 people in 2025 could not be sourced, so the $538-per-person basis (a division of those two numbers) is not used. FIRC's 2025 revenue was $8.98 million against $5.80 million of expenses; a funder will reasonably ask why the gap isn't met from reserves, and should.

7. Top up bystander naloxone outreach in worker housing and bars, through the existing harm-reduction provider

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CHECKED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
High Rockies Harm Reduction (a project of the Colorado Nonprofit Development Center), supplying bars, employers, and housing	**From November**	**$15k for staff time; kits free from the state**	**Overdose deaths among seasonal workers and residents**

Naloxone is free to eligible organizations from the state's Naloxone Bulk Purchase Fund, so money buys distribution, not kits. Bars and resort onboarding have to be supplied through the provider or the county; they can't order directly. In Massachusetts, communities with high naloxone uptake saw overdose deaths fall (Walley et al., BMJ 2013: rate ratio 0.54 at high uptake, 0.73 at lower uptake), and a US model estimated one death averted per 227 kits (Coffin and Sullivan, 2013). Both predate fentanyl and were not re-checked here.*

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: Summit residents' overdose deaths are down to 7 a year, so the return per dollar is modest, and the provider's existing contract is about $10k per county per year; $15k matches that scale better than the $25k proposed. Since May 2024 the state fund prioritizes high-risk groups and caps orders.

8. Keep SNAP and Medicaid from lapsing in a short-hours month: screen seasonal workers now and log volunteer hours

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · ECONOMIST · FOOD SUPPLY · ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CHECKED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Summit County Human Services and FIRC	Now, in the shoulder season; again before April	Staff time	Workers losing food and health benefits in the same month they lose hours

Adults aged 18–64 without dependents must log 80 hours a month of work, volunteering, or training to keep SNAP beyond three months in any 36. Volunteer hours count, alone or with paid work. Colorado applies the rule at each person's redetermination. From 1 January 2027 Medicaid adults at or below 133% of the poverty line face six-monthly checks with a similar test (80 hours, or $580 of income, in at least one month of the six). When snow is short and hours fall, both can bite at once.

Corrections: missing the hours starts the time limit; it does not cut benefits immediately. Whether Summit County has any area waiver, and how counties log volunteer hours, were not found.

9. Restore FIRC's weekly food buying for the winter, once it confirms money is still what limits it

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · FOOD SUPPLY · ECONOMIST · ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CHECKED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
FIRC, with the county	December to April	$5,000 a week for 20 weeks, $100k (in the ceiling only)	Midwinter rationing at the markets

FIRC cut weekly food buying from $15,000 to $10,000 in September 2025. Cash to FIRC, or grocery cards as the county used in November 2025, beats food drives, because FIRC buys to fill gaps.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: both figures are 13 months old. Check that FIRC is still buying at $10,000 a week and that money, not appointment slots, is the limit. The Summit Foundation's grants top out at $10,000 and its fall cycle is closed, so it can't fund this before the winter.

10. Pay the safe-parking fees for workers on the waitlist, and help car-dwellers through snow-emergency nights

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · FRONTLINE · ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CHECKED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Unsheltered in Summit, with volunteers	From November	About $75 a month per person (20 people × 5 months = $7,500, arithmetic; not in the envelope)	Workers sleeping in unmanaged spots, with no toilets and no one checking on them

The program served about 65 working people a year with a winter waitlist of about 20. Its lot gives toilets, bear-safe bins, and other people nearby.

Corrections: the fee is about $75 a month, not $45 (an older church lot). A county ban on street parking from 15 November to 15 April could only be found for Summit County, Utah, so it was dropped.

11. Hold a pre-season exercise on Tenmile and Vail Pass closures, including the gas line at Copper

UNVERIFIED · FEASIBLE · EMERGENCY MGR · ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CHECKED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Summit County Office of Emergency Management, with CDOT, the state patrol, and Xcel	1 December	Staff time	Losing time when a slide hits the highway and a utility line together, as in 2019

The 2019 slides closed I-70 and broke a gas line at Copper on the same morning. A tabletop run through the closure triggers, the shelter agreement (action 3), and the gas hazard costs only staff time.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

No evidence on how much such exercises reduce harm was found, so this is unverified rather than wrong.

12. Before summer 2027: close the fuel-break gaps and set spring water and fire restrictions benchmarked to 2002–03

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · NEXT SUMMER | HISTORIAN | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CHECKED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
White River National Forest, Summit County, and the towns; Denver Water for Dillon Reservoir	Restrictions decided in spring 2027	Existing budgets; Strong Future already funds wildfire mitigation	A June fire after a low-snow winter

Denver Water expects its system at about 60–62% full by 1 April 2027 (about 60% at Dillon), the lowest since 2002–03, when Dillon fell to 48%. On 12 June 2018, after a low-snow winter, the Buffalo Mountain Fire stopped short of about 1,400 homes at fuel breaks 300–500 feet wide cut in 2011–12; the Forest Service valued what they protected at about $913 million.

Corrections: the Dillon-specific figure comes from a news report, the systemwide one from Denver Water. That the fuel breaks "saved" the homes is the ranger's judgment, not a measured count.

13. Ask Copper's owner two questions: does every dorm room have a kitchen, and does the resort hold low-snow insurance whose payout could protect workers' hours?

UNVERIFIED | FOOD SUPPLY · ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CHECKED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
POWDR (Copper Mountain)	Before the season opens	A letter	Workers without kitchens going hungry on storm days when lifts close and wages stop

Low-snow cover is sold in Colorado: Arbol's product pays when snowfall measured in a reanalysis dataset falls below a chosen trigger, and it pays the resort, not its workers. Nothing public shows whether POWDR holds it. Copper's housing page lists 110 deed-restricted units and says nothing about kitchens or meals.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Unverified: no payout figure can be planned around, and the dorm-bed count is dated.

14. Resort job, not a grant: check AED coverage at lift tops and lodges, and keep promoting helmets

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · DEMOTED | PUBLIC HEALTH | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CHECKED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Copper Ski Patrol	Opening day	Resort operating budget	Cardiac deaths on the mountain, and some head injuries

Trained lay responders with defibrillators roughly doubled cardiac-arrest survival in a large trial (PAD, NEJM 2004). Helmets cut head-injury odds by about 60% (Sulheim, JAMA 2006) but have not been shown to cut deaths.

Corrections: Copper's own AED placement could not be confirmed, so ask before assuming a gap. Copper's January 2026 death and both 2024–25 Keystone deaths were helmeted, so helmets alone would not have changed most of last season's toll. Nothing here is related to El Niño.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHO DOES WHAT

RACI CHART

R = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal.

Action	Summit Fire & EMS	Summit County OEM	Summit County Human Services	FIRC	Building Hope & Sheriff's SMART	High Rockies Harm Reduction	Unsheltered in Summit	Copper Mountain (POWDR) & Metro District	CAIC & Forest Service	CDOT, state patrol & Xcel	Red Cross
1. CO alarms; never silence	**A/R**	**C**		**R**			**R**	**R**			
2. Men after a loss			**C**	**C**	**A/R**			**C**			
3. Copper-side warming site; car rule	**C**	**A/R**	**C**					**R**		**C**	**R**
4. Persistent-slab warnings at gates		**I**						**R**	**A/R**		
5. LEAP enrollment drives			**A/R**	**R**						**I**	
6. Emergency rent and utility fund			**C**	**A/R**							
7. Naloxone outreach top-up	**C**		**C**			**A/R**		**R**			
8. SNAP and Medicaid hours			**A/R**	**R**				**C**			
9. FIRC food buying			**C**	**A/R**							
10. Safe-parking fees; snow nights		**I**	**C**				**A/R**				
11. Pre-season closure exercise	**R**	**A/R**						**C**	**C**	**R**	**C**
12. Fuel breaks; spring restrictions	**R**	**C**							**A/R**		
13. Dorm kitchens; snow cover				**C**				**A/R**			
14. AEDs and helmets	**C**							**A/R**			

What the chart shows: **FIRC does the work in five rows and is accountable for two**: it is the trusted, no-ID door for the workforce, so most money below lands there. **Copper Mountain is accountable for three rows and does the work in four more**, which is more than a resort usually carries in these briefings; its housing, onboarding, and terrain gates are where the risks sit. **Summit County's emergency office owns the closure rows**, which need an agreement, not money.

WHERE MONEY DOES THE MOST

FUNDING

Verified and corrected. The county's Strong Future levy already pays for much of the mental-health and wildfire work, and the local foundation's fall cycle is closed, so outside money this month fills a real gap. It should go to rent and heat arrears, bereavement outreach, and a carbon monoxide pilot, not to lodging, kits, or food drives.

FLOOR	TARGET	CEILING	LARGEST UNCERTAINTY
$60k	$115k	$265k	

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The Strong Future levy (Ballot Measure 1A, November 2026), which funds more than half of Building Hope. If it passes, the mental-health line is a top-up; if it fails, $40k is far too little and the line needs redesigning

Arithmetic. Floor: FIRC rent and utility fund $25,000 + Building Hope $25,000 + High Rockies Harm Reduction $10,000 (its existing per-county scale) = **$60,000**. Target: FIRC $50,000 + Building Hope $40,000 + High Rockies $15,000 + carbon monoxide alarm pilot $10,000 (about 400 alarms at $25) = **$115,000**. Ceiling: FIRC rent fund $50,000 + Building Hope $40,000 + High Rockies $25,000 + alarms $50,000 (about 2,000) + FIRC food buying $100,000 (20 weeks × $5,000) = **$265,000**, the food line only if neither the county nor the foundation funds it. Above that, a county of about 31,000 cannot absorb more before the peak on top of Strong Future. The alarm price and the weekly food figure are planning assumptions. The only published cost-effectiveness figure, one death averted per 227 naloxone kits, applies to kits, which here are free; no placement has a published cost per death averted in this setting, so the ranking rests on mechanism. The target moved 12% from the $130k first proposed.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
FIRC, Family & Intercultural Resource Center (EIN 84-1252900)	Action 6: winter rent and utility arrears	$50k	Unrestricted grant	Rent fund "completely depleted" in October 2025; payments capped at about $800. 2025 revenue $8.98M against $5.80M of expenses, so ask about reserves	Partially confirmed
Building Hope Summit County (EIN 83-1871119)	Action 2: bereavement outreach for men, with SMART and the coroner's group	$40k	Restricted top-up	2025 income $2.17M, $1.12M of it from Strong Future; $40k is about 2% of its budget. The SMART and coroner elements were not verified	Partially confirmed

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
High Rockies Harm Reduction (via Colorado Nonprofit Development Center)	Action 7: naloxone distribution and training	$15k	Restricted grant	Holds a $100k two-year contract across five counties, about $10k per county per year; kits free from the state	Partially confirmed
Summit Fire & EMS	Action 1: carbon monoxide alarm pilot	$10k	Direct grant	No existing free-alarm program, so no duplication; installation not costed	Partially confirmed
FIRC	Action 9: restore weekly food buying	$100k (ceiling only)	Grant or county grocery cards	Cut from $15k to $10k a week in September 2025; check the current level first	Unverified
Summit County Human Services	Lodging for stranded travelers on overnight I-70 closures	$0	Dropped; replaced by an agreement	In February 2020 there were no vacancies; shelters were free congregate space opened by the Red Cross and the county	Dropped

The funder's one thing: El Niño is not a reason to give here; the ordinary winter and the deaths that follow a loss are. The cheapest life saved is a bereaved man whom someone calls in the month after the funeral, or a worker whose rent is paid so they never move into a car with a propane heater.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Do not do this

CONTRAINDICATED · ADVICE THAT WOULD COST LIVES HERE

Advice that circulates for this hazard and would cost lives, money, or trust here.

Do not plan around "El Niño means a big snow year"

CONTRAINDICATED (NARROWED) SKEPTIC

At Climax and Dillon, strong El Niño winters averaged slightly less snow than other winters, and ranged widely. Colorado Climate Center analysis finds the central mountains tend below average in moderate to strong events. Plans built on a big year staff the wrong season and expect water that may not come.

Instead: plan for an ordinary winter that might start dry, and use the daily CAIC forecast (action 4).

Do not assume a thin, slow-starting winter is a safer one

CONTRAINDICATED HISTORIAN

A shallow early snowpack grows weak, sugary layers that later snow loads into persistent slabs, the problem behind most Colorado avalanche deaths. CAIC described exactly this in 2023–24.

Instead: persistent-slab warnings from December (action 4).

Do not make "carry a beacon" the avalanche message

CONTRAINDICATED (NARROWED) SKEPTIC

Gear is not judgment. The 2013 Sheep Creek party was experienced and had discussed the hazard, and five died. Sidecountry reached through resort gates is avalanche terrain.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Instead: a trained partner, practised companion rescue, terrain choice, and the daily forecast.

Do not shelter in a car with the engine running unless the tailpipe area is dug out to the ground *

CONTRAINDICATED SKEPTIC; CORRECTED BY VERIFICATION

A buried car reached lethal carbon monoxide in 2.5 minutes with the windows closed and 5 minutes with them cracked. Sweeping the tailpipe clear still left dangerous levels; only a 12-inch path cleared to the ground brought it to zero.

Instead: clear the path, run the engine in short bursts, open a window, and head for a warming site (action 3).

Do not silence a carbon monoxide alarm as faulty, or run fuel-burning heaters without one *

CONTRAINDICATED EMERGENCY MGR · SKEPTIC

In Silverthorne in April 2025, residents tried to silence alarms they thought were faulty, and five went to hospital. A Dillon Valley home with no detectors sent seven to hospital in December 2021.

Instead: get out and call 911 (action 1).

Do not rely on traction-law fines to keep unequipped cars off Vail Pass

CONTRAINDICATED SKEPTIC

The state patrol wrote 425 traction-law citations in winter 2024–25 up to March, 338 of them to commercial vehicles. Fines come after the spin-out that closes the road.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Instead: check traction where cars change hands, at rental counters and lodging check-in.

Do not make data-collecting offices the only door to winter help

CONTRAINDICATED (NARROWED) FRONTLINE

Immigration enforcement activity reported in Summit County has caused widespread fear, and Latino residents have cancelled appointments that collect personal data. No local count of people avoiding services was found.

Instead: offer every winter message and alarm through FIRC's no-ID markets alongside the county's channels.

WHAT HAS HAPPENED HERE BEFORE THE RECORD

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
1960s	Climax mine tailings bury the old towns of Kokomo, Recen, and Robinson in Tenmile Canyon	Towns erased	Copper Mountain resort opens nearby in 1972
1982–83, 1997–98, 2015–16, 2023–24	Strong El Niño winters	Snow at Climax 424, 487, 480, and 495 cm, within the normal range	—
2002–03	Drought	Dillon Reservoir falls to about 48%	The benchmark for low water
2013 (20 April)	Sheep Creek avalanche, Loveland Pass	Five killed, Colorado's deadliest since 1962	—
2018 (12 June)	Buffalo Mountain Fire, after a low-snow winter	1,384 homes evacuated; none lost	Fuel breaks credited
2019 (7 March)	Slides close I-70 west of Copper and break a gas line at Copper	No injuries; I-70 closed about 18 hours	—

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
2020 (6–7 February)	Civil emergency; I-70 closed	800–1,000 vehicles stranded, no hotel rooms	Red Cross shelters in Silverthorne and Frisco
2021 (7 December)	Furnace carbon monoxide, Dillon Valley	Seven hospitalized; no detectors	—
2025 (April)	Carbon monoxide in a Silverthorne condo and at Arapahoe Basin	Five hospitalized after alarms were silenced	—
2025 (September – October)	FIRC cuts food buying; its rent fund runs dry	—	Only Dillon answers its appeal
2025–26	Record-low snowpack; ski visits down a quarter	—	—
2026 (January – May)	Eight suicides, all after a recent loss	—	Building Hope expands men's programs

The recurrence nobody has noticed: every I-70 closure here turns into two other emergencies at once, a sheltering problem and a carbon monoxide problem, because thousands of people end up idling in cars or crowding into units with gas appliances. A second pattern, which the historian lens proposed and the record only partly supports: a low-snow winter leaves a low reservoir, and a low reservoir has come before a June fire, as the 2017–18 winter came before the Buffalo Mountain Fire.

WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREE — RESOLVED AND OPEN

- **Open: does El Niño matter here at all?** Most lenses said no. The historian argued that a thinner El Niño base raises spring avalanche risk. Verification found evidence that thin early snow builds persistent slabs, but none tying El Niño to it; the station record shows only a slight dry tilt. Both views are kept: action 4 is framed on thin snow, not on El Niño.
- **Open: weather or the deaths that follow a loss?** The funder and the public health lens put suicide and overdose first; the emergency manager put closures and carbon monoxide first. The ranking puts carbon monoxide and men after a loss at the top, because both have recent local cases, and gives the overdose line less now that deaths have fallen.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **Resolved: shutoff protection.** A lens proposed medical certificates as the main defense. Verification found Colorado already bars cold-day shutoffs by regulated utilities, so the certificate matters mostly in spring and fall.
- **Resolved: cash for stranded travelers.** Proposed by the funder; dropped because there were no rooms to buy in 2020.

WHAT NOBODY COVERED — BLIND SPOT

Visitors and the uncounted workforce. Summit County's population roughly doubles in winter, but the death figures here are for residents. Visitors who die of cardiac events at altitude, workers on J-1 visas, and people without a fixed address may sit outside every count used in this briefing. No Spanish-language source was searched, Copper's own worker housing was not inspected, and no one in Copper or Frisco was interviewed.

HOW TO READ THIS — METHOD

The panel is author-built. Eight simulated expert lenses were used to generate these recommendations. Where they agree, that is a strong hypothesis, not a consensus of the field. Every recommendation was then independently checked for evidence, transferability to this location, and feasibility before the peak; the verdict tags carry the result.

Mortality figures are resolved at Climate Impact Lab impact-region scale, roughly 300,000 people. They are not neighborhood figures. The El Niño projection covers *heat only*; cold, avalanches, carbon monoxide, and food prices are additional to it and are carried here by the station record, the historical record, and the supply-chain evidence rather than by a published number.

HOW THIS BRIEFING WAS PRODUCED — METHODOLOGY

- **Scope.** The request was for a street address in the Copper Mountain resort village (ZIP 80443). The briefing was built for Copper Mountain and Frisco, which share ZIP code 80443, in Summit County, Colorado. Climate Impact Lab impact region: Summit County, inferred (the county holds about 31,000 people, well below a typical region). Population and mortality figures are county-level. Sub-county detail is used for hazard exposure and action design, not for death counts.
- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

2027. It covers heat only. It is never added to the Impact Map's long-run projections or quoted from the map's GDP-denominated mortality. Where heat is not the dominant hazard, the historical record carries the hazard instead of a borrowed number.

- **Premise test.** Computed for this briefing from NOAA GHCN-Daily records for Climax (USC00051660) and Dillon 1E (USC00052281), each winter classed by the peak October–December, November–January, and December–February Oceanic Niño Index values (strong at 1.5 or more).
- **Expert panel.** Eight simulated expert lenses (emergency manager, public health scientist, frontline responder, skeptic, economist, historian, philanthropist, and food supply chain analyst) each researched this place independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief. Each was pointed to the Boulder, Colorado briefing of 8 October for state-level context.
- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias before it counted. Contradictions were kept. Actions were ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak, each was given a payer and trigger or marked unfunded, and the funding placements were reconciled against the ranked list.
- **Verification.** Six verifier agents checked the carbon monoxide and closure actions, the health actions, the financial actions, the food actions, the funding envelope, and the avalanche action and contraindications, on evidence, transferability, and feasibility. They fetched Colorado statute, the state utility regulator's cold-weather rule, CDHS LEAP and SNAP pages, Health First Colorado, CAIC's season summary, Denver Water, ProPublica's nonprofit filings, USDA ERS, BLS, the Red Cross, and the BMC Emergency Medicine study directly. Financial actions were checked for availability, payer, trigger, and redundancy. The envelope was re-summed.
- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.
- **Adaptation Inventory.** Not consulted for this briefing; no verifier reached it. When read in full for earlier briefings (96 entries), it held nothing on carbon monoxide, avalanches, suicide prevention, or highway closures, so no precedent is expected, but that is untested here.
- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (medicines and firearms in a crisis, naloxone, carbon monoxide, and when to call 911) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.
- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total, and no local figure is invented; where data is thin, the report says so. Every source is listed below.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **Limits.** The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from web-available sources, not human experts. Many searches for "Summit County" returned Summit County, Ohio, or Summit County, Utah; those results were discarded, and one claim (a winter street-parking ban) was dropped because it could only be found for Utah. Not reachable or not found: a Colorado coroner annual report, census tables for ZIP 80443, Copper's AED placement and dorm kitchens, the source of FIRC's 2025 assistance totals, and the count of I-70 closures in 2024.

References · verified in this briefing unless marked.

Premise: CPC Oceanic Niño Index · GHCN-D Climax · GHCN-D Dillon 1E · 9News on Colorado Climate Center analysis · Colorado Sun, El Niño forecast · OpenSnow outlook (lens) · 2026 snowpack · 2025–26 ski visits

Population and health: Census QuickFacts, Summit County · KUNC, suicide statistics · Summit Daily, suicide rate · Colorado Health Institute · Overdose deaths (CDPHE via Gazette) · Naloxone Bulk Purchase Fund · Coffin and Sullivan summary · 2024–25 skier deaths · Copper death, Jan 2026 · CO incidents, Apr 2025 · Dillon Valley CO, Dec 2021 · CRS 38-45-104 · Griffin et al. 2004, buried-car CO · Summit Fire & EMS history

Housing, money, and benefits: Unsheltered in Summit · Safe-parking fees · Housing study, Spanish speakers (lens) · Immigration enforcement fears · LEAP · FY27 continuing resolution · PUC cold-weather shutoff rule · Medical certificates · SNAP work rules, Colorado · SNAP desk aid, Feb 2026 · Medicaid six-month checks · Strong Future renewal · FIRC filings · FIRC rent fund depleted · Building Hope filings · Building Hope annual report 2025 · Region 5 opioid council · Arbol low-snowfall cover · Copper employee housing

Hazards and operations: Copper gas leak, 2019 · Vail Pass slide, 2019 · Red Cross shelter, 2020 · Silverthorne highway-closure page · Traction-law citations · Sheep Creek avalanche report · Persistent-slab share of deaths · Sidecountry accidents · CAIC 2023–24 season summary · Denver Water reservoir forecast · Lake Dillon levels · Buffalo Fire fuel breaks · Tenmile Canyon towns (lens)

Food supply chain: USDA ERS food price outlook · BLS food at home, Mountain · FIRC food budget cut · County SNAP assistance · 2020 Glenwood closure and groceries · Props LL and MM

Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory

Generated 12 October 2026 for Copper Mountain and Frisco, Colorado. El Niño Ready is volunteer-run and is not affiliated with Climate Week NYC, The Climate Group, or Columbia University.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.